by contrast had very little material interest in Aksai Chin, which is largely desert and scrubland. In Arunachal Pradesh in the eastern sector, the situation is reversed. India is determined that China cannot have a presence south of the McMahon Line because Chinese forces could 'break out' from there into the plains of the Indian North-East. On the other hand, it is unclear why China wants to occupy the southern slopes of Arunachal: militarily, it is a challenging place to hold, as the supply lines will be long and difficult to maintain. Beijing's real interest is probably the Tawang monastery there, a site with symbolic and therefore strategic significance. The monastery is under Indian control, but China regards it as important for the integration and stability of Tibet.

Beyond the quarrel over boundaries, India and China have differed on the status of Tibet. In the 1950s, India held a view that it had interests in and responsibility towards Tibet, given its presence there from the days of the British Raj. The historical link with Tibet through Buddhism and trade reinforced that view: India had cultural–moral obligations towards a kin civilization and was the main source of vital supplies including food. After Tibet's integration into China in 1950, Delhi's aim was to ensure the province retained a degree of cultural and social autonomy. With its defeat in the 1962 war, India concluded it could no longer play a role in backing Tibetan autonomy: the dangers were too great, and in any case the 1954 treaty with China, which had committed Beijing to maintain Tibet's autonomy, had expired by 1962. India's involvement in Tibetan affairs could now only be to host the Dalai Lama and the exiles.

While India sees itself as a passive guardian of the Dalai Lama and exile community, China thinks that Delhi is active in supporting him, stirring anti-China sentiment in the exile community, and interfering in Tibet itself. In Chinese thinking, the border quarrel with India and Beijing's continuing struggles with Tibetan integration are linked. The border between India and China is essentially Tibet's border with India. So, it must be delineated in a way that ensures India cannot militarily or politically influence Tibetan affairs. The reverse is also the case. Stability in Tibet is vital for China's border control with India. A Tibetan insurgency or rebellion could